10
exercises to understand *Why* you impulse spend

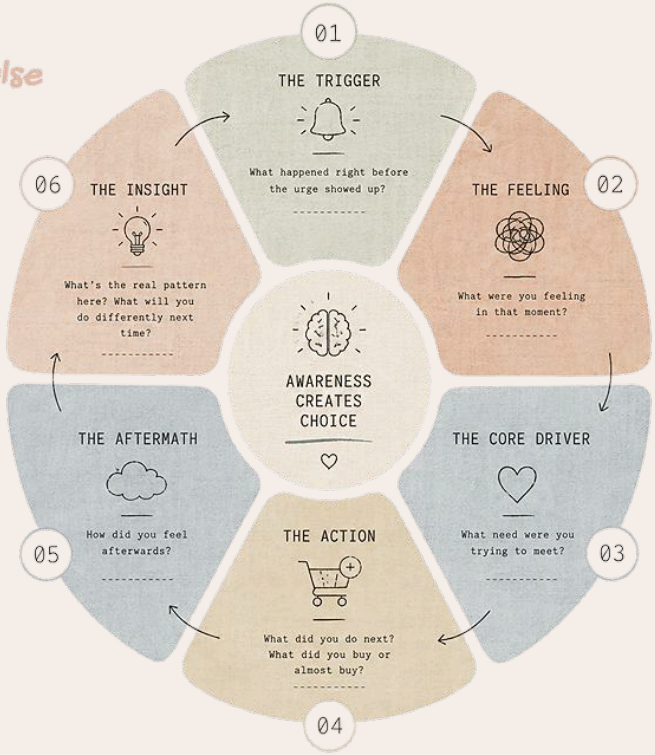
A practical, fill-in workbook built around the Pause framework — helping you decode your spending triggers, name your core drivers, and build a plan that actually fits how you think and feel.

THE *Decoded Impulse* WHEEL

Every impulse follows a pattern. When you can name each part, you can interrupt it.

HOW TO USE:
Use this wheel to decode your recent impulse purchase or strong urge to buy.

The more you practice, the more automatic awareness becomes.



EXAMPLE

- Trigger: Scrolling Instagram at night
- Feeling: Bored, restless
- Core Driver: Escape
- Action: Added items to cart and purchased
- Aftermath: Brief high, then guilt and regret
- Insight: I use shopping to escape boredom. Next time I'll take a walk or watch an episode instead.

You can't always remove the trigger, but you ca change what happens nex

CONTENTS

What's inside

EX 1	Your Spending Snapshot	A quick baseline assessment of your current relationship with spending	p3
EX 2	Trigger Identification	Identify which of the 12 triggers most often set off your impulse urges	p4
EX 3	The Decode Method	Practise the two-layer decode on 5 real purchases from your recent history	p5
EX 4	Core Driver Deep Dive	Explore the emotional need underneath your most frequent impulse driver	p6
EX 5	The Trigger × Need Matrix	Map your personal trigger-to-driver combinations with an interactive grid	p7
EX 6	Your Spending Environment Audit	Identify the environments, times, and contexts that raise your risk	p8
EX 7	The 30-Minute Pause Protocol	Build a personalised interruption strategy tailored to your triggers	p9
EX 8	Your If–Then Plan	Write your own personalised if-then spending plan using your decoded data	p10
EX 9	7-Day Awareness Tracker	A one-week daily habit grid to build the decode habit from scratch	p11
EX 10	Weekly Reflection Prompts	8 guided questions to close out the week with genuine self-awareness	p12

HOW TO USE THIS WORKBOOK

You can work through all 10 exercises in one session, or pick up one at a time over a week. There's no right way — just honest engagement. The exercises build on each other, so starting at Exercise 1 is recommended. When you're ready to continue tracking daily, **Pause** (the free browser-based app) picks up exactly where this workbook leaves off.

EXERCISE 01

Your Spending Snapshot

Before we decode anything, let's establish your baseline — how you currently feel about your spending, not what the numbers say. Honest first impressions are more useful than curated ones.

> **Instructions:** Answer each question quickly. Don't overthink — your first instinct is usually the most accurate data you have.

IN ONE SENTENCE, HOW DO YOU FEEL ABOUT YOUR RELATIONSHIP WITH SPENDING RIGHT NOW?

WHAT TRIGGERS YOUR SPENDING MOST OFTEN? (GUT ANSWER)

WHAT DO YOU USUALLY FEEL AFTER AN IMPULSE BUY?

RATE YOUR CURRENT AWARENESS OF YOUR SPENDING PATTERNS

1	2	3	4	5
none	rarely notice	sometimes notice	usually notice	full clarity

WHICH OF THESE STATEMENTS FEEL TRUE FOR YOU RIGHT NOW? (TICK ALL THAT APPLY)

- [ ] I often buy things and later don't remember the exact moment I decided to.
- [ ] I know roughly what triggers me, but I can't seem to stop it in the moment.
- [ ] I feel like I should be better at this — like it's a discipline problem.
- [ ] Spending gives me a brief sense of relief, comfort, or control.
- [ ] My spending feels disconnected from what I actually value or care about.
- [ ] I've tried budgeting apps but they didn't address the underlying pattern.

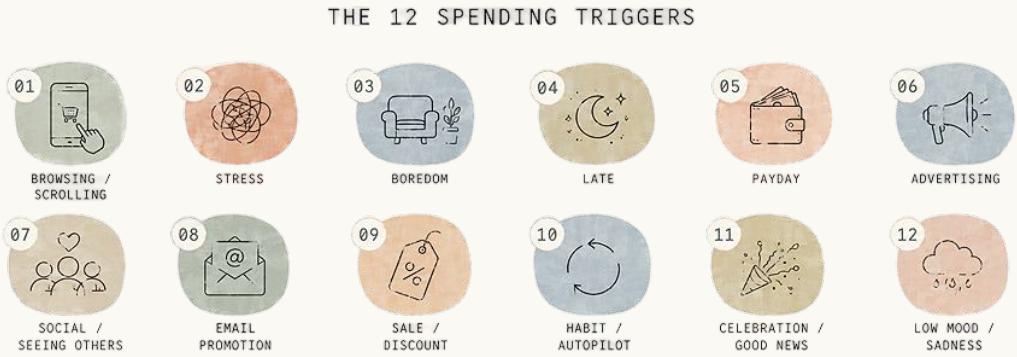
WHAT WOULD GENUINELY UNDERSTANDING YOUR SPENDING PATTERNS CHANGE FOR YOU?

> **Remember:** This workbook isn't about willpower or discipline. It's about understanding. The goal after these 10 exercises is not to spend zero — it's to spend with *awareness.*

EXERCISE 02

The 12 Spending Triggers — Which Are Yours?

Most people have 2-3 dominant triggers that repeat. The goal isn't to eliminate them — triggers are a normal part of life. The goal is to recognise yours so they lose their automatic power.



TICK THE TRIGGERS THAT RESONATE WITH YOU (SELECT ALL THAT APPLY)

- ☐ 📱 browsing / scrolling
- ☐ 😰 stress
- ☐ 😐 boredom
- ☐ 🌙 late night
- ☐ 💰 payday
- ☐ 📣 advertising
- ☐ 👥 social
- ☐ 📧 email promotions
- ☐ 🏷️ sale / discount
- ☐ 🔁 habit
- ☐ 🎉 celebration
- ☐ 😔 low mood

MY TOP TRIGGER IS:

MY SECOND TRIGGER IS:

WHEN EXACTLY DOES THIS TRIGGER TYPICALLY HIT?
(time, place, context)

DESCRIBE YOUR MOST RECENT TRIGGER MOMENT IN DETAIL:

KEY INSIGHT

A trigger is just the **match**. The fire is something deeper — an emotional need the purchase is attempting to meet. We'll decode that in Exercise 3.

EXERCISE 03

Decode 5 Real Purchases

Think back to 5 purchases from the last 2–4 weeks — bought or nearly bought. For each one, identify the trigger (what set it off) and the core driver (the emotional need underneath). The driver is the real answer.

Core drivers reference: relief · reward · escape · comfort · validation · excitement · connection · control · identity · FOMO· numbing · hope

ITEM / PURCHASE	BOUGHT OR RESISTED?	TRIGGER	CORE DRIVER	HOW YOU FELT AFTER

LOOKING AT YOUR 5 DECODED ITEMS — WHAT PATTERN DO YOU NOTICE?

WHICH CORE DRIVER APPEARED MOST OFTEN?

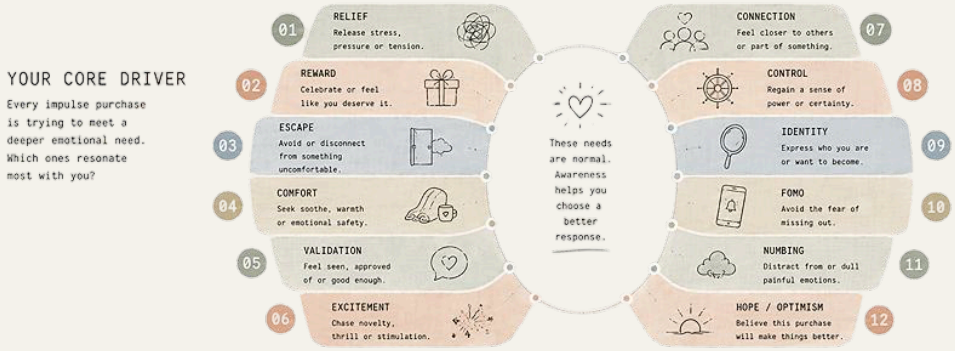
DOES THIS SURPRISE YOU? WHY OR WHY NOT?

The key shift: Once you can name "I was buying for escape, not because I needed the thing" — you've broken the automatic loop. The urge doesn't disappear, but it stops being invisible.

EXERCISE 04

Your Core Driver — Going Deeper

Your most frequent core driver is the emotional need that your spending keeps trying to answer. Understanding it more fully — where it comes from, what else it responds to — is where lasting change lives.



MY MOST FREQUENT CORE DRIVER (FROM EXERCISE 3):

IN YOUR OWN WORDS, WHAT DOES THIS NEED ACTUALLY FEEL LIKE WHEN IT ARISES?

WHAT OTHER (HEALTHIER) THINGS IN YOUR LIFE ALSO MEET THIS NEED?

WHEN THE NEED ARISES, WHAT WOULD IT ACTUALLY TAKE TO GENUINELY MEET IT?

IS THERE A PATTERN AROUND WHEN THIS NEED FEELS STRONGEST? (TIME, CONTEXT, EMOTIONAL STATE)

> REFLECTION
>
> The need itself is never the problem. **Relief, escape, comfort, connection** — these are all legitimate human needs. The question isn't "how do I stop needing this?" It's "what would genuinely meet this need, in a way I'll feel good about tomorrow?"

EXERCISE 05

Your Trigger × Core Driver Map

Not every trigger connects to the same need — and not every need gets activated by the same trigger. This matrix helps you see which combinations are most live for you. Click any cell that represents a real pairing you've experienced.

COLUMNS = CORE DRIVERS · ROWS = TRIGGERS · Tick any that applies to you

	relief/ numbing	escape/ comfort	reward/ excitement	validation/ connection	control/ identity	FOMO/ Optimism
fatigue / low energy - late night, boredom						
emotional load - stress, low mood / sadness						
passive consumption - browsing / scrolling, habit / autopilot						
external prompotion - advertising, email promotions						
social influence - social						
event based spending - payday, sale / discount, celebration / good news						

MY STRONGEST COMBINATION (THE ONE THAT FIRES MOST RELIABLY) IS:

HOW LONG HAVE YOU BEEN AWARE OF THIS COMBINATION?

WHAT TYPICALLY HAPPENS IN THE 30 MINUTES BEFORE THIS COMBINATION FIRES?

> **This combination is the target.** In Exercises 7 and 8, you'll build a specific protocol and if-then plan designed exactly for this trigger × driver pairing. The more specific the plan, the more effective it is.

EXERCISE 06

Your Spending Environment Audit

Environment shapes behaviour as much as intention does. This exercise helps you map the specific contexts, apps, times, and emotional states that raise your spending risk — so you can make small environmental changes that have outsized impact.

HIGH-RISK APPS & PLATFORMS (TICK THE ONES THAT MOST OFTEN LEAD YOU TO SPEND)

- ☐ Instagram
- ☐ TikTok
- ☐ Pinterest
- ☐ Email inbox
- ☐ ASOS/Zara/Shein
- ☐ Amazon
- ☐ Temu
- ☐ eBay
- ☐ Etsy
- ☐ Vinted
- ☐ YouTube
- ☐ Other:
- ☐ Other:
- ☐ Other:

HIGH-RISK TIMES OF DAY — RATE EACH ON A 1-5 RISK SCALE (1 = LOW RISK, 5 = HIGH RISK)

Morning (6-10am) 1 2 3 4 5

Afternoon (12-5pm) 1 2 3 4 5

Evening (5-9pm) 1 2 3 4 5

Late night (9pm+) 1 2 3 4 5

HIGH-RISK EMOTIONAL STATES (TICK ALL THAT APPLY)

- ☐ After a stressful or difficult day
- ☐ When I'm lonely or disconnected
- ☐ When I'm tired or depleted
- ☐ When I'm procrastinating something
- ☐ After seeing others' purchases online
- ☐ On payday or after receiving money
- ☐ Other: _____
- ☐ Other: _____

ONE SMALL ENVIRONMENTAL CHANGE I COULD MAKE RIGHT NOW:

ONE APP I COULD MOVE OFF MY PHONE'S HOME SCREEN:

Small friction = big results. Moving a shopping app one folder deeper, charging your phone outside the bedroom, or setting a 9pm screen-off habit can reduce high-risk exposure by more than 50% without requiring any willpower at all.

EXERCISE 07

Your 30-Minute Pause Protocol

The "wait 30 minutes" advice is useless without knowing what to do during those 30 minutes. This exercise helps you build a personalised interrupt protocol — specific to your trigger, your environment, and your core driver.



WHEN THE URGE HITS, WHAT DO I NOTICE FIRST IN MY BODY OR MIND? (THE SIGNAL TO ACTIVATE THE PROTOCOL)

BUILD YOUR PERSONAL 5-STEP PAUSE PROTOCOL — MAKE EACH STEP CONCRETE AND SPECIFIC TO YOU:

1. NOTICE — Name what you're feeling out loud or in writing

2. PAUSE — Exit the environment (close the app, put down the phone, change rooms)

3. MEET THE NEED — Do something that addresses the core driver directly

4. LOG — Write the item on a wishlist to review in 48 hours, not to buy

5. REFLECT — After the 30 minutes, check in: has the urge changed?

> **This protocol becomes automatic with repetition.** The first few times will feel effortful. By the 5th or 6th time, your brain will start running it before you consciously decide to. That's the habit forming.

EXERCISE 08

Write Your If–Then Plan

An if-then plan is a single sentence that pre-decides your response to a specific trigger. Research consistently shows that people who write if-then plans are significantly more likely to follow through than those who rely on motivation alone. The key is specificity.

> THE FORMULA
>
> **If [trigger + context], then I will [specific action that meets the need differently]."**

GOOD IF-THEN PLAN ✓

"If I'm in bed after 10pm and feel an urge to open a shopping app, then I'll put my phone on charge, make a drink, and write one thing I'm looking forward to tomorrow."

TOO VAGUE ×

"If I want to buy something impulsively, then I'll wait 30 minutes." (No specific context has been identified. No specific action. There is nothing to anchor the habit to.)

MY PRIMARY IF-THEN PLAN (BASED ON MY TOP TRIGGER × DRIVER FROM EX 5):

IF ...

THEN I WILL ...

WRITE 2 MORE IF-THEN PLANS FOR YOUR OTHER COMMON TRIGGERS:

IF ...

THEN I WILL ...

IF ...

THEN I WILL ...

The Pause app generates an if-then plan automatically from your decoded data after you've logged at least 5 impulse items. Compare yours here with the one the app generates — they'll often point to the same core truth.

EXERCISE 09

7-Day Awareness Tracker

Use this grid for the next 7 days. Each evening, tick what applies. You're not aiming for a perfect week — you're aiming for an honest one. Pattern recognition is the goal here, not performance.

HABIT	MON	TUE	WED	THU	FRI	SAT	SUN
No-spend day							
Impulse urge arose							
Used pause protocol							
Resisted a purchase							
Decoded an item							
Used if-then plan							

DAY OF THE WEEK WHERE SPENDING IS HARDEST:

HOW MANY TIMES DID I FEEL THE URGE VS ACT ON IT THIS WEEK?

URGES FELT ACTED ON

WHAT MADE THE EASIEST DAY EASIER?

WHAT SURPRISED ME MOST THIS WEEK?



The Pause app makes this automatic. Once you're logging daily, your streak, no-spend days, and resisted items are tracked and charted for you — so this manual grid becomes a full insights panel over time.

EXERCISE 10

Weekly Reflection — 8 Prompts

These 8 prompts close out the workbook — and are the same ones inside the Pause app's Weekly Reflection tab. Return to them once a week. Honest, regular reflection is how short-term awareness becomes long-term change.

1. What were my 2–3 biggest spending moments this week?

2. Which trigger appeared most often this week?

3. What need was I most often reaching for through spending?

4. What was my hardest moment of resistance this week?

5. Did my spending this week reflect my values?

6. What am I proud of from this week?

7. What would I do differently next week?

8. What is one thing I want to remember from this week?

YOUR NEXT STEP

You've completed all 10 exercises. You now have a clearer picture of your triggers, your core drivers, and a personalised plan. **Pause** — the free browser-based app this workbook is built around — is where you take these insights and build them into a daily practice. Open it in any browser. No login. No download. Start with the Daily Log.

pause.futuresanctuary.co · free to use